

Opabinia

One of the weirdest prehistoric animals ever discovered, *Opabinia* had five eyes on stalks and a long, flexible trunk (proboscis) tipped with a grasping claw. This mouse-sized sea creature probably used its trunk in the same way an elephant does, picking up items of food with the tip and then passing them to its mouth.



▲ FOSSILS of *Opabinia* were discovered in a famous fossil bed in Canada called the Burgess Shale. The Burgess Shale contains surprisingly clear impressions of soft body parts that were buried in mud on the seafloor half a billion years ago during the Cambrian Period. There are so many weird and wonderful animal species in the Burgess Shale that their sudden appearance is known as the “Cambrian Explosion.”



Claw

